

“Oh, and what did he say to that?” I asked with cautious curiosity.

“Well, he had a funny look on his face at first, and then he said he would make us an offer.” “Oh,” I said, rocking my chair back against the wall; I sat there perched on two rear legs of the chair. Mike did the same thing. “Do you know what the offer is?” I asked. “No, but we’ll soon find out.” Suddenly, Mike’s dad burst through the rickety screen door and onto the

porch. Mike and I jumped to our feet, not out of respect but because we were startled.

“Ready boys?” Mike’s dad asked as he pulled up a chair to sit down with us.

We nodded our heads as we pulled our chairs away from the wall to sit in front of him.

He was a big man, about 6 feet tall and 200 pounds. My dad was taller, about the same weight, and five years older than Mike’s dad. They sort of looked alike, though not of the same ethnic makeup. Maybe their energy was similar.

“Mike says you want to learn to make money? Is that correct, Robert?”

I nodded my head quickly, but with a little intimidation. He had a lot of power behind his words and smile.

“OK, here’s my offer. I’ll teach you, but I won’t do it classroom-style. You work for me, I’ll teach you. You don’t work for me, I won’t teach you. I can teach you faster if you work, and I’m wasting my time if you just want to sit and listen, like you do in school. That’s my offer. Take it or leave it.”

“Ah... may I ask a question first?” I asked.

“No. Take it or leave it. I’ve got too much work to do to waste my time. If you can’t make up your mind decisively, then you’ll never learn to make money anyway. Opportunities come and go. Being able to know when to make quick decisions is an important skill. You have an opportunity that you asked for. School is beginning or it’s over in ten seconds,” Mike’s dad said with a teasing smile.

“Take it,” I said.

“Take it,” said Mike.

“Good,” said Mike’s dad. “Mrs. Martin will be by in ten minutes. After I’m through with her, you ride with her to my superette and you can begin working. I’ll pay you 10 cents an hour and you will work for three hours every Saturday.”

“But I have a softball game today,” I said.

Mike’s dad lowered his voice to a stern tone. “Take it or leave it,” he

“I’ll take it,” I replied, choosing to work and learn instead of playing